PAW & FOUND



Pet Travel Checklist

& Packing Guide

Everything you need for a smooth trip with your pet

Car • Air • Hotels • Stress-free packing lists

📋 Pre-Trip Checklist

🗓️ 1 WEEK BEFORE

- [ ] **Vet checkup** — Health certificate if flying. Ensure vaccines are up to date.
- [ ] **Confirm pet-friendly accommodations** — Call to verify pet policy, any fees or size restrictions.
- [ ] **Update ID tags & microchip** — Include your cell number and destination contact info.
- [ ] **Refill medications** — Enough for the trip + 3 extra days. Get written prescriptions as backup.
- [ ] **Research nearby vets at destination** — Save the address and 24-hour emergency clinic info.

📦 DAY BEFORE

- [ ] **Pack pet bag** — Use the packing list on the next pages. Keep it accessible during travel.
- [ ] **Exercise your pet** — A good walk or play session helps them relax during travel.
- [ ] **Limit food before travel** — Light meal 3–4 hours before departure to prevent carsickness.

🚗 DAY OF TRAVEL

- [ ] **Potty break right before leaving** — Give them every opportunity to go.
- [ ] **Secure pet in car** — Harness, crate, or carrier. Never loose in the car or in the front seat.
- [ ] **Take a photo of your pet** — Current photo on your phone in case you get separated.

🏥 Vet Visit Prep & Documents

📄 DOCUMENTS TO BRING

- [ ] **Rabies vaccination certificate** — Required for most travel, especially across borders.
- [ ] **Health certificate (CVI)** — Required for air travel. Must be issued within 10 days of travel.
- [ ] **Vaccination records** — Full history. Some airlines and boarding facilities require them.
- [ ] **Prescription info** — Medication list with dosages, vet phone number, written Rx.
- [ ] **Microchip registration** — Confirmation of registration and current contact info.
- [ ] **Recent photo of your pet** — Printed and digital copy. Include a photo of you WITH your pet.
- [ ] **Pet insurance card & policy number** — Travel emergency coverage info.

❓ QUESTIONS TO ASK YOUR VET

- [ ] Is my pet healthy enough for travel? Any special concerns?
- [ ] Should I get anti-nausea or anti-anxiety medication?
- [ ] Do I need any additional vaccines for my destination?
- [ ] Can you recommend a vet clinic near my destination?
- [ ] Should I bring flea/tick/heartworm prevention?

🚗 Car Travel Packing List

- [ ] **Seat cover / hammock** — Protect your seats and keep pet contained.
- [ ] **Safety harness or crate** — Crash-tested restraint is safest.
- [ ] **Leash + backup leash** — Rest stops require quick leash-ups.
- [ ] **Collar with current ID tags**
- [ ] **Food & water** — Enough for the drive + 1 extra meal.
- [ ] **Travel bowls** — Collapsible silicone bowls save space.
- [ ] **Bottled water** — Different water can upset stomachs.
- [ ] **Poop bags** — More than you think you need.
- [ ] **Medications** — In original containers.
- [ ] **First aid kit** — See travel first aid section.
- [ ] **Favorite blanket / bed** — Familiar scent reduces anxiety.
- [ ] **Chew toy or puzzle** — Occupies them during the drive.
- [ ] **Calming aids** — Thundershirt, pheromone spray, vet-approved supplements.
- [ ] **Paper towels + wet wipes** — For messes and muddy paws.
- [ ] **Trash bag** — For used poop bags and trash.
- [ ] **Window shade** — Keep direct sun off your pet.

✈️ Air Travel Packing List

CARRY-ON (IN-CABIN PETS)

- [ ] **Airline-approved carrier** — Must fit under seat. Check airline dimensions!
- [ ] **Absorbent pad / puppy pad** — Line the carrier. Bring spares.
- [ ] **Health certificate** — Within 10 days of travel. Keep accessible.
- [ ] **Collapsible water bowl** — Offer water before and after security.
- [ ] **Small bag of treats** — For calming and reward. Not a full meal.
- [ ] **Leash and harness** — You'll need to remove pet from carrier at security.
- [ ] **Calming spray or wipes** — Pheromone-based, apply to carrier 15 min before.

CHECKED / CARGO (IF APPLICABLE)

- [ ] **IATA-compliant hard-sided crate** — Check airline requirements carefully.
- [ ] **"Live Animal" stickers** — Clearly visible on all sides of crate.
- [ ] **Frozen water dish** — Attached to door. Won't spill; melts over time.
- [ ] **Zip-tied food bag** — Attached to top of crate with feeding instructions.
- [ ] **Contact info on crate** — Your name, phone, destination, pet's name.

> **💡 Pro Tip**
>
> Book direct flights when possible. Avoid layovers in extreme heat or cold. Notify the flight crew that your pet is on board — they may offer extra consideration.

🏨 Pet-Friendly Hotel Tips

- [ ] **Call ahead to confirm pet policy** — Don't rely on website info. Ask about fees, size limits, and pet areas.
- [ ] **Request a ground-floor room** — Easier for potty breaks. Near an exit is ideal.
- [ ] **Bring a "Do Not Disturb" sign for the door** — Prevent housekeeping from startling your pet.
- [ ] **Pet-proof the room immediately** — Check under beds for pills, trash, and hazards from previous guests.
- [ ] **Set up a "home base"** — Bed, water bowl, toy in one spot. Familiar setup reduces stress.
- [ ] **Never leave pet alone until they're calm** — Some pets panic in unfamiliar rooms. Test with short absences first.
- [ ] **Use the crate when you're out** — Prevents damage, escape, and anxiety. Leave TV or radio on low.
- [ ] **Know where the nearest emergency vet is** — Save the address before you arrive.

🚗 In-Car Safety Guide

🔒 Always Restrain Your Pet

Unrestrained pets are dangerous — to themselves and to you. In a 30 mph crash, a 60 lb dog becomes a 2,700 lb projectile. Use a crash-tested harness, carrier, or crate.

🛑 Never in the Front Seat

Airbags can kill a pet, even in a carrier. The back seat is safest. If using a crate in the cargo area, secure it so it can't slide.

🌡️ Temperature Awareness

Never leave pets in a parked car — not even "just for a minute." At 70°F outside, the car reaches 100°F in 20 minutes. Cracking a window does almost nothing.

🛑 Take Breaks Every 2–3 Hours

Pets need potty breaks, water, and a chance to stretch. Never let your pet out without a leash — rest stops are full of unfamiliar smells and hazards.

🤢 Carsickness

Signs: drooling, whining, lip-licking, vomiting. Face your pet forward, crack a window for fresh air, and avoid feeding right before travel. Ask your vet about anti-nausea medication.

🏥 Travel First Aid Kit

- [ ] Gauze pads & rolls
- [ ] Disposable gloves
- [ ] Self-adhering bandage (Vetrap)
- [ ] Muzzle or soft restraint
- [ ] Blunt-tip scissors
- [ ] Hydrogen peroxide 3%
- [ ] Tweezers (ticks, splinters)
- [ ] Benadryl (ask vet for dosage)
- [ ] Antiseptic wipes (alcohol-free)
- [ ] Styptic powder (for nail bleeds)
- [ ] Saline eye wash
- [ ] Emergency phone numbers
- [ ] Digital thermometer
- [ ] Copy of medical records

🧘 Calming Tips for Anxious Travelers

- [ ] **Familiar scents** — Bring their bed or a blanket that smells like home. Don't wash it right before the trip.
- [ ] **Pheromone products** — Adaptil (dogs) or Feliway (cats) sprays, collars, or wipes. Apply 15–30 minutes before travel.
- [ ] **Thundershirt / anxiety wrap** — Gentle, constant pressure calms many pets. Put it on before they get anxious.
- [ ] **Exercise before travel** — A tired pet is a calmer pet. Long walk, vigorous play, or a run before departure.
- [ ] **Calming music** — Classical music or "Through a Dog's Ear" playlists. White noise machines help in hotels.
- [ ] **Practice short trips first** — Build up to long journeys. Start with 10-minute drives to fun places (park, not vet).
- [ ] **Stay calm yourself** — Your pet reads your energy. Speak in a normal, reassuring voice. Take deep breaths.
- [ ] **Medication as last resort** — Talk to your vet about trazodone, gabapentin, or other anti-anxiety meds. Test at home first.

> 💡 **Remember**
>
> Most travel anxiety improves with practice. Each successful trip builds your pet's confidence. Celebrate small wins — a calm 10-minute drive is progress!

📝 Trip Notes

Hotel reservation #, flight info, vet appointment details, pet sitter contact, notes from the road, what worked well, what to improve next time...

🧳 Safe travels!

Your best adventures include your best friend.